contrast, appeared woolly-headed, ill-informed and hopelessly unprepared for tough questioning.

He tried to appear confident, often speaking of himself in the third person, saying things like, ‘I will give you an insight into what Rahul Gandhi thinks.’ But when asked a direct question of whether he was ready for the Modi challenge, Rahul would veer off and say, ‘What Rahul Gandhi wants to do is to empower the women in this country—he wants to unleash the power of these women.’

In fact, women’s empowerment, RTI and ‘system change’ were recurring themes that were repeatedly mentioned by Rahul through the interview, often irrespective of the question being asked. Even a specific question on the 2002 Gujarat riots led to Rahul speaking loftily of strengthening RTI, women’s empowerment and democracy. It was as though he was speaking from another planet.

His political naivety was also exposed when Arnab grilled him on the Congress’s role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots and contrasted it with the party’s stand on the 2002 Gujarat riots. Rahul tried to claim, rather foolishly, that the Congress government in 1984 had tried to stop the violence while the BJP had actively abetted them in 2002. Strangely, rather than offer an unequivocal apology for 1984, of the kind that prime minister Manmohan Singh had already issued, Rahul schoolboyishly pussyfooted around it, saying, ‘Firstly, I wasn’t involved in the riots. I wasn’t part of it. I was not in operation of the Congress party.’

To blame Modi for 2002 was one thing; to absolve the Congress of responsibility for the massacre in 1984 was quite another. All Rahul needed to do was sound genuinely contrite, perhaps even offer a heartfelt apology, promise complete support to the legal process and even point out that the Congress had appointed a Sikh prime minister subsequently. He did none of it. Not surprisingly, his prevarication provided an opportunity for Sikh groups the very next day to protest against the Congress. The year 1984 was back on the front pages. In the eyes of the Sikh protestors, Rahul, far from being the youth leader promising a new era, had taken his place among the